Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S. \

When we arrived in the United States, it was very difficult. We didn't know the language. Had no friends, and didn't have a car. We weren't familiar with the market, and we did have a phone to understand the map. We faced every kind of problem. The market was very far away, and buying food, especially in the winter, was very challenging. Gradually, we made friends and learned the language. It took about a year and a half to two years to understand and figure out what we needed to do and where to use things. Slowly things got better. Once our caseworker came and mentioned a market called Smith', saying it was close to our house and that we could shop there. They did not show us how to use the card and it was a 20 minutes' walk away.

A. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

The day we arrived in the US we received help but after a year, we were informed that for any issue, we should go to DWS. I didn't apply for food stamps because we thought we might not qualify. It felt overwhelming, and we were unsure about the process, so we decided to hold off on applying.

i. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

ii. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

B. : Can you tell me when food became a problem?

i. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs during these times?

ii. Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

C. You indicated that you never had problems with food in the last 12 months. Research shows that many refugees experience food insecurity. Can you explain what things have helped you to have enough food for yourself and your family?

We try to make our money last until the end of the month by saving and spending wisely. We buy things at the right time to use them properly and avoid waste. We keep good track of our finances and manage our lives to use resources effectively daily.

D. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

We had food stamps when we first arrived, for about four or five months. Once we started working, we had them for another month, but then they stopped we also had Medicaid for a year before it was stopped, When I pregnant, I reapplied, and they gave it to us again. We still have Medicaid now, but I'm not sure they might stop it.

i. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

Yes, we asked our friends for advice, and they suggested that we go to the refugee center, but we have not gone yet. I'm not sure if they will assist us or not. My husband was not given Medicaid because they said he doesn't qualify. Since I was pregnant, I received Medicaid but now they have informed me after a year that assistance will be cut off. This uncertainly adds to our worries about what will happen next

ii. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

Everyone who comes here must receive help. In my opinion, someone must teach them everything, from how to navigate the markets to what types of food are available and what is not. They should also learn how to obtain household items and how to use banking cards. This support is vital because many people face significant challenges. I have seen and experienced how difficult it can be. My own experience has shown me just how important it is to have guidance in these areas.

iii. You indicated that you have used the WIC program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

The WIC program is only available if. a person is pregnant or has a child under five years old. I had a doctor's appointment, and other friends were there too. It was five months, and the doctor also mentioned that I could use this program. My friends told me as well. Initially, I didn't know about five months after my pregnancy, but then my friends told me. That I could benefit from this program. I went to the WIC clinic and explained my issues. They asked If I had Medicaid, and I said yes because if you have government assistance, you can receive the WIC program. They asked how much my husband works, and what our income is. I told them about my husband's income, and they said I qualified. Then they gave me an application to fill out. Fortunately, our house was close to this clinic, and I went there.

iv. Can you explain your experience with using this program?

This program we receive is very helpful. With about 6$ I can buy vegetables and fruits. The support from WIC greatly contributes to our food needs, giving me a sense of comfort and well-being. I went there myself, and they assessed my situation. Based on their programs, they provided me with his assistance. I'm not sure how many years it will last, but it is very helpful. My child didn't take to breastfeeding and uses formula, which is quite expensive, around 20$ each. We don't have enough money to buy it, this support is a big help for me.

E. You indicated that in the last 12 months, you often/always worried that the food you were able to eat would hurt your health and well-being, can you tell me more?

2. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.

When we first arrived here, we thought there was nothing available, especially when it came to vegetables like okra, which were abundant in Afghanistan. However, we found that they are not as readily available here. Sometimes, we see them in the local markets, but not often. Initially, we believed that many foods were simply unavailable. But as we became more familiar with the area, we learned that everything can gradually be found. We also discovered halal markets here. At first, we thought there was no such thing as fresh bread, but we learned that they bake it in the halal markets. This experience has opened our eyes to the variety of options available that we didn't realize existed at first.

A. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

It is very important to adapt to the culture here, and it takes time for a person to get familiar with everything. Initially, when we arrived, we didn't eat any outside food. Over time we discovered that some of those familiar foods can be found here as well, and we have started to use them. Gradually things are getting better as we learn more about the local culture and foods.

B. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

Everything can be found here, especially in stores like Smith's and Walmart. The vegetables and other items that we used to have in Afghanistan are also available in these stores. If something is not available, there are halal markets specifically for Muslims, which offer the products we need. We buy from those markets because they cater to our dietary requirements making it easier for us to maintain our traditions while living here.

C. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

No one told us anything; we had to find things on our own or ask our friends. The only people who helped us were these friends who had come here before us. Without them, we would not have known anyone to ask about where the markets are or where to buy certain items. They offered significant help, guiding us to the place we needed to go. Most of our friends were very supportive, letting us know that the things we needed could be found in specific markets.

i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

Their support was crucial to us when we first arrived; they helped us find a place to live since we didn't have jobs at the time. Our case is still with CCS, and they are managing it. The most significant assistance they provided was securing s home for us, as having a place to live is very important. We only had a few household items for two people, but gradually we learned to adapt and built up what we needed over time.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

We barriers we face are primarily related to income. They assess our situation based on our earnings, and if our income exceeds a certain threshold, we become ineligible for government assistance. This means that if we earn too much, we're expected to provide for ourselves, which can be challenging. Apart from this, I don't see any other significant obstacle; the biggest hurdle is the income assessment that determines our eligibility for support.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

If every family had a case worker who could assist them more actively. It would make a significant difference. Even if they just checked in occasionally, it would help. Many Afghan immigrants are not familiar with the systems here and may not know what to do. Having someone who could come at least once a month to check on their progress would be incredibly beneficial. Some children struggle with reading and might need someone to help them understand important documents that arrive. This kind of support would be a tremendous help. Personally, my English is good, I can't manage my issues, but everything here is documented, and it can be difficult to comprehend. Some important papers come, and it's hard to understand them, and we can't take them to anyone for help.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

It would be ideal if someone could be sent once a month to check on things, as everything is confidential and needs to remain private within the family. That person could conduct a thorough assessment, looking into everything and helping to advance our situation. They could ask about the workload, and how much income someone can earn in a week and provide guidance accordingly. This approach would be excellent if the government took responsibility for it, ensuring that families receive the support they need while maintaining their privacy.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

After all these years, we have gradually started to adapt to life in America and connect with its people. When we first arrived, we were far away from our families, didn't speak the language, and felt quite isolated. We didn't have a car, and we didn't know anyone. Everything was difficult, even the way we dressed. However, over time, we learned and adjusted. Now, we see ourselves integrating with the community and finding solutions to our challenges. It's a process, but with each passing day, we are becoming more accustomed to our new environment.